



Mi Max 3 with 7 inch screen

The Mi Max 3 is rumored to be in tablet territory with a screen size of 7-inches and an aspect ratio of 18:9. <http://digit.in/MiMax3>



Tech vs bad habits

Stanford researchers have discovered a way to cure bad habits by zapping brain centre for impulsive actions. <http://digit.in/BrainZap>

Sony WH-1000XM2

The best in its class

Last year, when Sony introduced the flagship MDR-1000X pair of headphones, we were left mightily impressed by how very good they sounded. It gave its primary rival, the formidable Bose QuietComfort 35, a run for its money. This is how the next iteration performed in our tests.

Performance

Straight off the bat, the Sony WH-1000XM2 looks, and sounds mighty close to the previous generation 1000X. However, the low frequencies are incredibly tight, and are delivered with impressive clarity, definition and character. The bass notes sound well pronounced, clean and wholesome, forming a very solid backbone to support the rest of the frequency range.

The clean, solid lows are well supported with bright, cheery vocal performance. The warm audio timbre has almost the right mix of sweetness and mellow smoothness, which essentially suits a wide range of vocals. It also retains the intricacies very, very well, which further suits your Norah Jones-ish rainy-day playlists, aided along by the noise cancellation.

This brings us to the topic of the high frequencies. While the highs are clean, subtly smooth and enjoyable, they do sound a bit muted in comparison to the rest of the frequency range. This slight issue also persists with the higher mids, where the 1000XM2 somewhat attenuates the high pitches, certain high riffs and hi-hat rolls in favour of a bassier audio output. The effect is still quite rich, but may lead you to use an external equaliser.

Sony has also considerably improved on the soundstaging, which we stated sounded a bit too concentric in



Price
₹29,990



FEATURE.....	90
PERFORMANCE.....	90
VALUE.....	60
DESIGN.....	90

the previous generation. The WH-1000XM2 does better to emulate an open concert hall and lend a sense of individual channeling and direction to the instrument sources, and it is not too claustrophobic to listen for long hours.

The active noise cancellation has also been worked on. While the previous generation almost felt like there was a deliberate, invisible curtain always buzzing between your ears and the rest of the world, the unnerving nature of the noise cancellation here has been considerably reduced to make the overall sound feel more natural.

The only bit where the Sony WH-1000XM2's performance really faltered is in picking up voice when in call.

It particularly struggles when in crowded public places, and a slight flaw in the noise cancellation management persists where when you pick up a phone call, the noise pass filter automatically switches on and lets surrounding noise in to the voice of the caller, which ends up in the caller barely being able to hear what you're saying, unless you yell at the top of your voice.

Design, Gestures and Battery Life

Follow premium audio makers such as Audio-Technica, Bose, Bowers & Wilkins have consistently produced better looking headphones. However, the gesture-based playback controls are the best in class. The gesture-receptive earpad is on the right. The central point acts as the play/pause and calling operator, swiping up from centre increases volume, swiping down reduces volume, swiping right forwards tracks, and swiping left rewinds. The actions can be triggered through taps on the rim as well. This becomes almost second nature in the long run, to a point where you actually miss gesture-based controls on other headphones.

Battery life has also been improved, and ever since the one full charge that we put it through over a week back, I've been playing music for over 25 hours of playback now. The Sony WH-1000XM2 takes about three hours to charge fully.

Verdict

The Sony WH-1000XM2 are a pair of very well-sounding headphones, and is certainly one of the best around at its price. There are a few minor faults, like the outside noise filtering through when on call, and the fact that the battery is non-replaceable, which means that the battery stamina will deplete in the long run.

That said, it is right now the best pair of premium, active noise cancelling supra-aural wireless headphones at its price in India right now, on overall terms. Unless it is overturned by a drastic new competitor, we expect it to remain this way for quite some time.

—Souvik Das

SPECIFICATIONS

DRIVER: 40 mm | INPUT: Micro-USB, Stereo mini jack |
FREQ. RESPONSE (NORMAL): 4 Hz - 40K Hz | FREQ. RESPONSE (BLUETOOTH): 20 Hz - 20K Hz / 20 Hz - 40K Hz (L2AC) | NFC: Yes | CORD LENGTH: 1.5 m.

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